

“ [AN EMPEROR] UNDER WHOM **EVERYBODY** WAS **PERMITTED** TO DO **EVERYTHING.** ”

Fronto, Roman orator, on Emperor Nerva, from Cassius Dio's *History of Rome*

DOMITIAN (51–96) BECAME ROMAN EMPEROR

after the unexpected death of his brother, Titus (39–81). Domitian had never commanded armies and was unprepared for the exercise of supreme power. He had some success in his early campaigns, but he over-extended himself against the Dacians, and in putting down a legionary revolt led by **Saturninus**, the governor of Germania Superior. This distraction allowed **Decebalus, King of the Dacians** (r. 87–106), to renew his war against Rome, and Domitian was forced to pay off the Dacians with an annual subsidy.

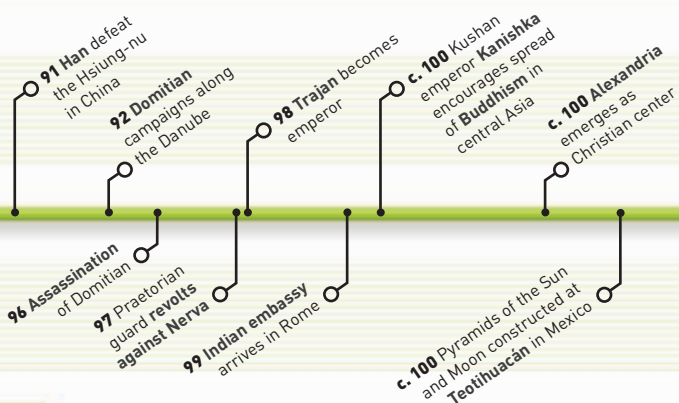
The conspiracy of Saturninus led Domitian to become paranoid and he had many senators executed for treason. In September 96, he was murdered in a palace conspiracy and the Senate chose the aged **M. Cocceius Nerva** (30–98) to replace him. The Senate then voted to destroy all statues of Domitian and to recall those he had exiled. However, in 97 Nerva faced a mutiny of the praetorian guard, who demanded the punishment of Domitian's murderers. Nerva was forced to give in, weakening his authority. His position was further diminished by his lack of an heir. To rectify this he adopted M. Ulpius Traianus (**Trajan**), the governor of Upper Germany, a man with a strong military backing. Nerva died soon afterwards and Trajan became emperor.



Emperor Domitian

Domitian's reign began well, but his descent into tyranny proved too much for his opponents, who had him assassinated.

In **Central Asia**, the northern Hsiung-nu confederation (see 146–131 BCE) collapsed in 89, allowing the Han to make large gains in the region, led by **general Ban Chao** (32–102). Ban Chao became protector-general of the Western Regions in 92, and reestablished control over the key oases along the **Silk Route**. By the time he retired in 102 the Han controlled most of the Tarim Basin. **Chinese state organization** became very complicated under the Han. Three supreme officials supervised large, complex departments. Each of these was subdivided into nine ministries. Governors oversaw each region, with regions divided into over 1,000 counties, each supervised by a magistrate. Eunuchs became increasingly influential at the Han court.



Trajan's Column, in Rome, gives a visual account of Trajan's campaigns against Decebalus in the Dacian Wars.

EMPEROR TRAJAN (98–117) WAS FROM A ROMAN FAMILY

who had settled in Spain—he was the first emperor to come from a Roman province rather than Italy. Having returned to Rome from Germany in 100 to claim his throne, he started a new **Dacian War** against Decebalus in 101. From a base at Viminacium (in modern Serbia), he pushed into central Dacia, and fought a major engagement at Tapae, in which both sides suffered serious losses. When Trajan's legions neared the Dacian royal capital at **Sarmizegetusa Regia**, Decebalus sued for peace, agreeing to give up his army's weapons and siege equipment, and to demolish his remaining forts. The Roman army did not withdraw totally, establishing a legionary base near the mountains

Sacred city

This ruined temple is in the Dacian capital, Sarmizegetusa Regia (in modern-day Romania). It contained the kingdom's most sacred shrines.

and building a bridge across the Danube at Drobeta to allow easier access across the river. Three years later, in 105, the Senate declared that Decebalus had violated the treaty, and Trajan embarked on his **Second Dacian War**. This time the legions reached, and took, Sarmizegetusa in 106. Decebalus fled and then committed suicide to avoid capture. The Romans acquired an enormous amount of treasure in Dacia, which allowed Trajan to embark on a building spree, including the construction of a **new Forum** in Rome. Dacia was annexed as Rome's first province across the Danube. It remained in imperial hands for over 160 years.

Some time around 106 the Roman governor of Syria annexed the **Nabataean kingdom**, which became the Roman province of Arabia. It was not Trajan's last acquisition in the east—in 113 he set off on a campaign against **Parthia**. He began by attacking Armenia in 113–114, but it was his

331,000 kg
SILVER

165,500 kg
GOLD

The Dacian Fortune

The large amount of treasure Trajan acquired in Dacia allowed him to build impressive monuments to commemorate his Dacian victory.

campaign against Parthia itself that gave him greater success in the east than any previous Roman emperor. By late 114 the Armenians had submitted to him, and he pushed into Mesopotamia, capturing the Parthian capital of **Ctesiphon**. By the end of 115, Trajan had reached the Persian

